

« For Nigeria, chaos has been the only constant. Too many cooks spoiled the broth for the African giant »

World Cup winner — was knocked out of the 2004 European Championships, it decided to tear its existing blueprint apart and build another from scratch.

Its youth programme, called the Nachwuchsleistungszentrum, churned out stars like Toni Kroos, Thomas Müller, Manuel Neuer and Mario Götze. A decade later, Götze — a product of Borussia Dortmund's youth academy — volleyed his name into immortality as Germany became world champion yet again.

A similar plan was conceptualised by Italy legend Roberto Baggio in his project 'Renewing the Future' after the Azzurri, then defending champions, crashed out of the 2010 World Cup in the group stage.

But within 17 months, he chose to walk away.

"A 900-page program was presented in December 2011, but it remained a dead letter for a year. So I drew my conclusions: I don't like sitting in positions, but rather getting things done," Baggio, resigning from the post of president of the technical sector of the Italian Football Federation, said.

The years that followed still yielded some fruits of Baggio's vision.

Italy won Euro 2020, produced prominent European stars in Gianluigi Donnarumma (left) — a treble winner with Paris Saint-Germain — Nicolò Barella, a two-time Champions League runner-up, and even Sandro Tonali, who helped Newcastle United win its first trophy in nearly half a century. Yet, with all of them in the squad, the ship could not be steadied against Bosnia and Herzegovina.

Marcello Lippi, the last World Cup-winning coach of Italy, had once said, "A group of the best players does not necessarily make for the best team."

Italy had developed a DNA influenced by Giovanni Trapattoni's *zona mista* (an Italian style of football prevalent in the 1960-70s) and Arrigo Sacchi's 4-4-2 — both that were built on

a simple creed: defence wins titles.

That cathedral now looks to be crumbling — neglected and abandoned.

Italian players are moving to foreign leagues, and the last time an Italian club won the Champions League was 16 years ago — the same year Italy last won the World Cup.

In the current national team, four of the 11 regular starters — Donnarumma, Riccardo Calafiori, Tonali and Mateo Retegui — play outside Italy, with its main striker (Retegui) playing in Asia. In contrast, in the 2010 World Cup-winning squad, all players featured in Serie A.

Off the field, the rot runs deeper. Gabriele Gravina clung to the Italian FA presidency despite Italy failing to qualify for Qatar 2022, until he was forced to walk the plank after the 2026 qualifying debacle.

Who did Italy turn to as coach? Gennaro Gattuso — a fine player who, as a manager, had fallen short of expectations at nine clubs.

For a country trying to return to the World Cup after 12 years, was that really the best step forward? Questions will arise and Italy will need answers, or risk going around in circles.

For Nigeria, chaos has been the only constant. Too many cooks spoiled the broth for the African giant, as the Super Eagles were grounded before takeoff for the second World Cup cycle in succession.

In the 2022 qualifying campaign, Nigeria replaced Gernot Rohr, who coached in the initial qualifiers, with Augustine Eguavoen before the penultimate round. The team fell to Ghana on the away goals rule.

In the next World Cup cycle, the inconsistency gave way to further drama. Several players from the team that finished runner-up in the 2023 African Cup of Nations (AFCON) were promised real estate rewards, which reportedly never arrived.

The team even boycotted the AFCON 2025 qualifier against Libya after being stranded at the airport for 12 hours.